



March 11, 2026

Sharon Kershbaum, Director
District Department of Transportation
250 M Street SE
Washington, DC 20003

Dear Director Kershbaum,

Consider what happens when a wheelchair user in downtown Washington, D.C., needs to be picked up by a ride-hail, a taxi, or a paratransit van.

The driver circles. There is nowhere to stop. The curb is metered parking, end to end, block after block. So the driver pulls into the travel lane, or the bike lane, or a crosswalk. The doors open ten feet from the sidewalk. Wheelchair ramps on accessible vehicles are engineered to bridge an eight-inch gap between the vehicle floor and a level curb. Instead, the ramp must reach down to the asphalt—double the drop, a steep grade, aimed into moving traffic. The rider rolls across drainage grates, broken pavement, standing water. In winter, ice. If the vehicle has a side-loading ramp, it cannot deploy at all—there is no access aisle, no level surface, just the flank of a car wedged between two parking meters with six inches of clearance.

For a wheelchair user waiting downtown, a blocked curb is not an inconvenience. It is the end of the trip. That is not an exaggeration. That is a Tuesday.

This is the daily, structural reality in a city that has 20,000 metered parking spaces downtown and so few accessible pick-up/drop-off zones that DDOT does not even publish a count.

As Chair of the Multimodal Accessibility Advisory Council, established under D.C. Official Code § 50-2361.31, we are writing to demand that DDOT begin immediately converting metered parking spaces into ADA-compliant Pick-Up/Drop-Off zones throughout the downtown core, with a phased plan for citywide deployment. Seventy-five thousand disabled residents of this city deserve a curb that works for them.

The Numbers

Let me put the scale of this failure in a table, because it deserves to be stared at.

Curbside Asset	Count	Who It Serves
Residential Permit Parking	150,000	Long-term private car storage
Metered Parking	20,000	Short-term private car storage
Commercial Loading Zones	1,400	Freight and deliveries
Diplomatic Parking	600	Treaty obligations
ADA Pick-Up/Drop-Off Zones	Unknown	People with disabilities

The District cannot even tell us how many ADA-accessible loading zones exist. What we do know is that 600 spaces are reserved for diplomatic parking—and it is almost certain that foreign governments have more dedicated curb in this city than disabled residents do.

Forty percent of D.C. households do not own a car. People with disabilities are twice as likely to live in those households. These are not people who chose to be car-free for the climate. They are people for whom a taxi, a ride-hail, or a paratransit van is the *only* option—and the District has decided that the curb those vehicles need to reach belongs to someone else's parked Honda Civic.

Why This Keeps Happening

The public debate about curbside access in this city has been poisoned by a false narrative that blames bike lanes. That is wrong, and DDOT knows it is wrong. The actual barriers are structural, and they are all within DDOT's power to address.

1. Daylighting has pushed loading demand into the midblock—where it has nowhere to go.

DDOT's own Vision Zero strategy prohibits parking within 40 feet of signalized intersections and 25 feet of crosswalks. This is correct policy. Daylighting saves lives. But it has eliminated the places where taxis and ride-hails have historically picked up passengers. That demand did not vanish. It moved to the middle of the block, where every inch of curb is locked into metered parking. The result is double-parking in travel lanes and bike lanes—the very behavior daylighting was supposed to prevent.

2. The revenue trap.

Downtown metered parking generates significant revenue. The Penn Quarter performance parking pilot increased meter revenue by 17 percent. DDOT depends on this money. Converting meters into PUDO zones—which generate little or no revenue—is a direct hit to the transportation budget. The District is asking disabled residents to subsidize its road maintenance by surrendering the curb space they need to private car storage that generates fees.

This is the fiscal equivalent of telling a wheelchair user to wait because the parking meter is more important.

3. The engineering excuse.

ADA-compliant loading zones require a 60-foot clear zone, a 5-foot access aisle, and a surface slope no steeper than 1:48. These are real constraints. Many midblock sidewalks are built over 19th-century vaults that cannot bear the regrading. Intersections, which are structurally clear of vaults, are exactly where daylighting has removed all loading.

But here is the part DDOT leaves out of every briefing: *not every block has a vault*. Not every midblock sidewalk exceeds the slope threshold. The engineering constraints are real where they exist, and they are an excuse everywhere else. DDOT has never conducted a block-by-block audit to identify which downtown blocks *can* accommodate midblock ADA zones. Until that audit exists, "engineering challenges" is not a reason. It is a way to avoid counting.

The Data Says It Works

DDOT's own curbFlow pilot tested reservation-based loading at nine locations in the District. Commercial drivers reserved spaces over 15,000 times in three months. Double parking dropped 64 percent. Illegal U-turns dropped. The surrounding blocks got safer.

The pilot also showed that ride-hail dwell times average less than 2.5 minutes. A single well-placed PUDO zone can serve 24 passengers per hour. A metered parking space, by contrast, serves about one person per hour. The math is not close: converting one meter into one PUDO zone gives twenty-four times more people access to the curb.

Seattle's Flex Zone program—funded by a USDOT SMART grant—has already digitized its curb, installed sensors, and published real-time occupancy data. Their hierarchy is explicit: in commercial areas, access for people comes first, storage comes last. Seattle found that nearly 80 percent of their commercial loading zones were occupied by unauthorized users. They did not conclude that loading zones do not work. They concluded that enforcement and visibility need to match the infrastructure.

Floating Platforms: The Solution DDOT Already Designed

On streets with protected bike lanes, the answer is a floating loading platform—a raised section at sidewalk level that extends across the bike lane buffer, giving passengers a level surface to deploy ramps and cross safely. This design is in DDOT's own Bicycle Facility Design Guide, Version 2. It reconciles bike infrastructure with accessible loading. It works.

The reason these platforms are not “everywhere” is that they require a 5-foot buffer width, which on narrow streets means removing a travel lane. That is a political problem, not an engineering problem. DDOT has the design. It has the specifications. What it lacks is the willingness to tell drivers that a wheelchair user's access to the curb matters more than a second travel lane.

The Law Is Clear

Title II of the ADA requires public entities to ensure that programs, services, and activities are accessible to individuals with disabilities. Curbside infrastructure is a public service. When the District allocates 20,000 spaces to private cars and cannot even document how many it provides to disabled passengers, that is not a resource constraint. That is a violation of the law's requirement to provide meaningful access.

The 2022 federal lawsuit filed by the DC Center for Independent Living documented exactly this: street redesigns that left wheelchair users stranded in bike lanes and floating parking lanes with no path to the sidewalk. The District settled aspects of that case rather than defend its designs in court. MAAC does not want another lawsuit. We want loading zones.

The Transportation Improvements Amendment Act of 2024 gave the DDOT Director greater discretion in network planning and explicitly moved away from “automobile delay” as the primary success metric. The moveDC 2021 framework targets 75 percent non-auto commute trips by 2032. Every metered space that stays a metered space is a bet against DDOT's own stated goals.

On behalf of the Multimodal Accessibility Advisory Council, we formally resolve:

That DDOT immediately begin converting metered parking spaces into ADA-compliant Pick-Up/Drop-Off zones throughout the downtown core, starting with a block-by-block engineering and structural audit to identify feasible midblock locations, and that DDOT adopt ADA PUDO zones as a standard curbside element in all future capital projects and corridor redesigns—with the goal of universal coverage across the District.

Specifically, we are asking for:

1. A block-by-block structural audit of the downtown core (bounded by Massachusetts Avenue, the waterfront, Rock Creek, and the Anacostia River) to identify every location where midblock ADA PUDO zones are physically feasible—accounting for sidewalk vaults, slope, utility conflicts, and existing tree canopy. PUDO zones must be sited to avoid removing mature trees. Deadline: 120 days.
2. Immediate installation of ADA-compliant PUDO zones at a minimum of 100 downtown intersections and midblock locations within 180 days, prioritizing high-demand corridors identified by ride-hail data, Metro station proximity, and hospital/medical facility adjacency. PUDO zones near intersections must respect pedestrian sightlines and must not obstruct crosswalks or reduce the visibility of pedestrians waiting to cross.
3. Floating loading platforms on every street with a protected bike lane where DDOT's own design guide shows they are feasible—starting with the corridors identified in the DCCIL lawsuit.
4. A new curbside revenue model—such as paid PUDO reservations or delivery zone pricing—that decouples DDOT's budget from static metered parking, removing the fiscal barrier to converting meters into loading zones.
5. ADA PUDO zones written into every moveDC corridor project and every future capital improvement as a *mandatory* design element, not an optional add-on.
6. A phased citywide rollout plan, with annual targets, submitted to the Council and published publicly.
7. A briefing to MAAC within 60 days on the audit methodology, initial site selections, and implementation timeline.

We want to be direct. The District has 170,000 spaces dedicated to storing private automobiles and does not even track how many spaces are dedicated to picking up and dropping off people who cannot drive. That is not a policy position. It is an indictment.

The engineering challenges are real in some places and overstated in most. The revenue concerns are legitimate and solvable. The political difficulty of removing parking is genuine and irrelevant to the legal obligation. None of these are reasons to maintain a curbside allocation that treats disabled residents as an afterthought.

Seventy-five thousand people in this city need the curb to work for them. Right now, it works for parked cars. Fix it.

We look forward to your response.

Sincerely,

Dr. Karthik Balasubramanian

Chair, Multimodal Accessibility Advisory Council

